

Research Methodology in Public Administration

Proposal Writing and Report Writing

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Research Problem and Research Objectives

From a General Area of Interest to a Focused Research Study

Research Area → Research Topic → Research Problem → Research Questions
→ Research Objectives

Where Does Research Begin?

Research generally begins with a **broad area of interest**.

For example:

Broad Area

Public Administration

The researcher gradually narrows the broad area into a specific, focused, and researchable issue.

From Broad Area to Research Topic

Broad Area

Public Administration



Specific Area

Digital Governance



Research Topic

Digital Public Service Delivery

What is a Research Topic?

A **research topic** is the broad subject or area that a researcher intends to investigate.

Examples

- ▶ Digital Governance
- ▶ Public Service Delivery
- ▶ Citizen Participation
- ▶ Local Government
- ▶ Administrative Reform

A topic alone is not a research problem.

From Research Topic to Research Problem

A researcher must identify a specific issue, difficulty, or gap within the broader research topic.

Research Topic

Digital Public Service Delivery



Specific Issue

Limited use and effectiveness of digital public services



Research Problem

What factors affect the effectiveness of digital public service delivery?

What is a Research Problem?

A **research problem** is a specific issue, difficulty, knowledge gap, contradiction, or unanswered question that requires systematic investigation.

A research problem may involve:

- ▶ A practical problem
- ▶ A gap in existing knowledge
- ▶ Contradictory findings
- ▶ A policy-related issue
- ▶ An unexplained phenomenon
- ▶ A theoretical problem

Sources of a Research Problem

Research problems may emerge from:

- ▶ Literature review
- ▶ Previous research
- ▶ Existing theories
- ▶ Research gaps
- ▶ Contradictory findings
- ▶ Personal experience
- ▶ Observation
- ▶ Social problems
- ▶ Administrative problems
- ▶ Policy issues

Characteristics of a Good Research Problem

A good research problem should be:

1. Clear and specific
2. Researchable
3. Relevant
4. Significant
5. Feasible
6. Ethically acceptable
7. Supported by available evidence or data

Preliminary Questions Before Selecting a Problem

Before selecting a research problem, ask:

- ▶ What exactly do I want to study?
- ▶ Why is this issue important?
- ▶ What is already known about the issue?
- ▶ What remains unknown?
- ▶ Is the problem researchable?
- ▶ Can I access the required data?
- ▶ Is the study feasible within available time and resources?

Research Gap

A **research gap** refers to an area where existing knowledge is:

- ▶ Limited
- ▶ Incomplete
- ▶ Outdated
- ▶ Contradictory
- ▶ Unexplored

Example

Although digital public services are increasingly available, limited evidence may exist regarding citizens' satisfaction with these services in a particular context.

Identifying the Research Problem

Area of Interest



Review of Literature and Context



Identification of an Issue or Gap



Narrowing the Focus



Clearly Defined Research Problem

Statement of the Problem

The **statement of the problem** clearly explains:

- ▶ The existing situation
- ▶ The specific problem or issue
- ▶ The gap in knowledge
- ▶ Why the problem is important
- ▶ Why the problem requires investigation

General Structure

Context → Existing Situation → Problem/Gap → Need for Research

Example: Statement of the Problem

Digital technologies are increasingly being used to improve public service delivery. However, the availability of digital services does not necessarily ensure their effective use by citizens. Factors such as accessibility, digital literacy, infrastructure, and institutional capacity may influence the effectiveness of these services. Therefore, there is a need to systematically examine the factors affecting the effectiveness of digital public service delivery.

From Research Problem to Research Questions

Once the research problem is identified, it can be expressed through specific **research questions**.

Research Problem

What factors affect the effectiveness of digital public service delivery?

Possible research questions:

1. What factors influence the use of digital public services?
2. How satisfied are citizens with these services?
3. What challenges do citizens face?
4. What challenges do service providers face?

What are Research Objectives?

Definition

Research objectives state **what the researcher intends to achieve** through the study.

Research objectives:

- ▶ Guide the research process
- ▶ Define the scope of the study
- ▶ Provide direction for data collection
- ▶ Guide data analysis
- ▶ Help maintain focus throughout the research

General and Specific Objectives

General Objective

The general objective expresses the **overall purpose** of the study.

Example:

To examine the effectiveness of digital public service delivery.

Specific Objectives

Specific objectives break the general objective into **specific and manageable components**.

They explain what the researcher will specifically investigate.

Example of Research Objectives

General Objective

To examine the effectiveness of digital public service delivery.

Specific Objectives:

1. To identify the major factors affecting digital public service delivery.
2. To assess citizens' satisfaction with digital public services.
3. To examine the challenges faced by citizens in accessing digital services.
4. To explore the challenges faced by service providers.
5. To suggest measures for improving digital public service delivery.

Characteristics of Good Research Objectives

Good research objectives should be:

- ▶ Clear
- ▶ Specific
- ▶ Relevant to the research problem
- ▶ Researchable
- ▶ Achievable
- ▶ Feasible
- ▶ Logically connected to one another

Action Verbs for Research Objectives

- ▶ Identify
- ▶ Examine
- ▶ Analyze
- ▶ Assess
- ▶ Explore
- ▶ Describe
- ▶ Compare
- ▶ Evaluate
- ▶ Investigate
- ▶ Determine
- ▶ Explain
- ▶ Understand

Example

To examine the factors influencing citizens' satisfaction with digital public services.

Research Problem, Questions and Objectives

Research Problem

Identifies **what** needs to be studied.

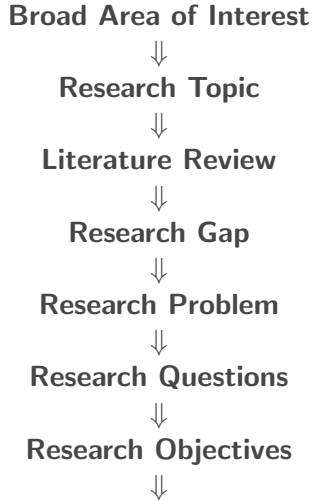
Research Questions

Specify **what** the researcher wants to know.

Research Objectives

Explain **what** the researcher intends to achieve.

From Research Interest to Research Proposal



Key Takeaway

A Research Topic tells us

What area we are interested in.



A Research Problem tells us

What needs to be investigated.



Research Objectives tell us